

Immigration, Crime, and Prosperity

The Economic Drivers of Growth in German Districts

APPLIED ECONOMICS
WISE25/26

Ömer Furkan Çoban

Prof. Dr. Jürgen Bitzer
Dr. Bernhard Christopher Dannemann
Abigail Opokua Asare

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Agenda

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1. Introduction

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1.1. Motivation

Relevance of the Topic

From Social Challenge to Economic Asset

- **Shifting the Narrative:** Immigration is not just a social phenomenon; it is a **fundamental driver of regional prosperity**.
- **The “Integration Success” Lens:** Moving beyond “Simple Population Shares” (Quantity).
- **Focusing on Labor Integration Efficacy (Quality):** Does the labor market successfully absorb foreign talent?
- **Turning Stability into Growth:** Analyzing the interaction between **Public Safety** (Property Damage/Crime) and economic performance.

1.2. Research Question & Hypotheses

Guiding Our Analysis

“To what extent does regional integration success drive GDP per capita in German districts, and how does the safety environment moderate this relationship?”

- H_1 : **Capital Accumulation**: Higher capital stock per capita is positively correlated with GDP growth.
- H_2 : **Integration Efficacy**: Regions with higher labor integration efficacy exhibit superior economic performance.
- H_3 : **Social Stability**: Higher rates of property damage (as a proxy for crime) act as a deterrent to regional prosperity.
- H_4 : **Demographic Dividends**: The age structure (share of children and youth) significantly impacts the long-term economic trajectory.

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2. Literature

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2. Literature Review

- **D'Amuri and Peri (2014) : Immigration, Jobs, and Employment Protection: Evidence from Europe Before and During the Great Recession**
 - **Data:** EU-LFS (European Union Labour Force Survey) and OECD EPL database.
 - **Scope:** 1996–2007, 15 Western European countries (Panel Data).
 - **Finding:** Immigrants and natives act as complements, where immigration triggers a productivity shift by pushing natives toward more complex, higher-paying tasks.
- **Piopiunik and Ruhose (2017) : Immigration, Regional Conditions, and Crime: Evidence from an Allocation Policy in Germany**
 - **Data:** PKS (Police Crime Statistics), BA (Employment Agency), and Destatis.
 - **Scope:** 1996–2005, West German Districts.
 - **Finding:** Immigration's impact on crime is primarily driven by regional economic conditions such as local unemployment and population density.
- **Degler, Liebig, and Senner (2017) : Finding their Way: Labour Market Integration of Refugees in Germany**
 - **Data:** IAB-BAMF-SOEP Refugee Survey, BA administrative data, and OECD indicators.
 - **Scope:** 2013–2017, Germany (National level analysis).
 - **Finding:** Successful integration depends on rapid labor market access and institutional frameworks that align migrant skills with local economic demand.

3. Data

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3.1. Data Sources: PKS (Crime Data)

Bundeskriminalamt (BKA) – Polizeiliche Kriminalstatistik

- **Dataset:** Official police crime statistics covering all German districts.
- **Timeframe:** 2003 – 2021
- **Core Variable:** *Property Damage Rate* (Sachbeschädigung).
- **Purpose:** Used as a proxy for the regional economic environment, social stability, and investment security.
- **Source:** BKA PKS Dataset

3.2. Data Sources: INKAR (Prosperity & Demographics)

Indikatoren und Karten zur Raum- und Stadtentwicklung

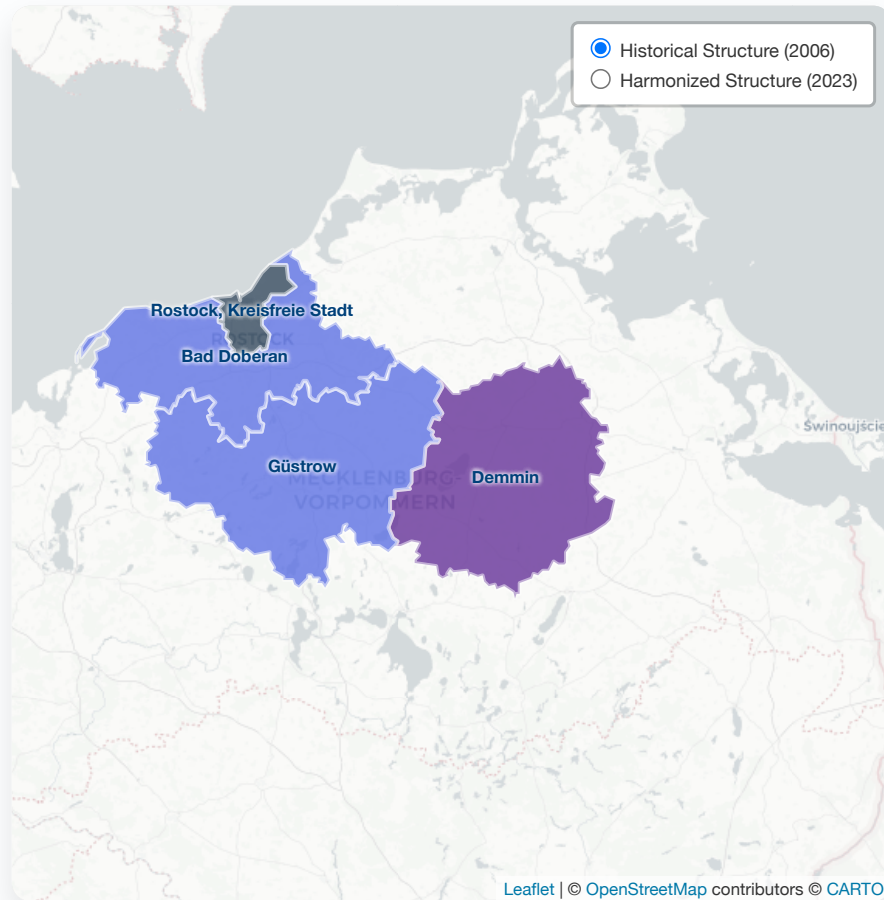
- **Dataset:** Maintained by the Federal Institute for Research on Building, Urban Affairs and Spatial Development (BBSR).
- **Timeframe:** Multiple decades up to recent years.
- **Core Variables:**
 - **Prosperity:** GDP per Capita
 - **Demographics:** Population(Zensus 2011), Age structure (youth shares), Foreigner Share, Foreign Labor Supply Pressure, Labor Integration Efficacy.
- **Source:** INKAR Database

3.3. Data Sources: StatistikPortal (Capital Stock)

Top-Down Distribution Methodology

- **Datasets:** State Capital Stock (Net Fixed Assets) and District Gross Value Added (GVA).
- **Timeframe:** 2003 – 2021
- **Core Variable:** *Capital Stock per Capita* (K_{it-1}).
- **Challenge:** Capital stock (K) is only reported at the State (s) level, not the District (d) level.
- **Solution:** We employed a sector-specific top-down distribution algorithm. We weighted State-level capital data by the District's share of Gross Value Added (GVA) to accurately proxy regional capital intensity. [Details →](#)
- **Source:** Statistikportal VGRdL

3.4. Spatial Harmonization



Territorial Reform (Gebietsreformen)

- **The Challenge:** Over the 19-year period, district borders are not static (merges/splits). This creates *artificial jumps* in the time-series data.
- **The Solution:** Spatial Harmonization of all datasets (PKS, INKAR, Capital Stock) to the **static 2023 boundaries** using BBSR's *Umsteigeschlüssel* (Conversion Keys).
- **Weighting Strategy:** Used population-proportional weighting ($Weight_{pop}$) rather than area, as socio-economic activity centers in populated zones.
- **Formula:**

$$Value_{Target} = \sum_{Source} (Value_{Source} \times Weight_{pop})$$

Ex 1: Rostock (Merger)

UNIT	WEIGHT	CONTRIBUTION
Bad Doberan	1.0	7,223
Güstrow	1.0	9,354
Total		16,577

Ex 2: Demmin (Split)

UNIT	WEIGHT	CONTRIBUTION
Demmin to Mecklenburgische Seenplatte	0.824	5,949
Demmin to Vorpommern-Greifswald	0.176	1,271
Total		7,220

3.5. Data Refinement: Census 2011 Adjustment

Addressing Population Shocks: Census 2011 Correction

- **The Problem:** The 2011 Census revealed significant overestimations in German population registers (*Fortschreibung*). This caused artificial “jumps” or “breaks” in per capita metrics. Traditional crime rates (PKS) using unadjusted population figures would suffer from measurement bias.
- **The Solution:** Recalculation of Crime Rates. We re-estimated the denominator (population) for the pre-2011 and transition years using a backward-correction method.
- **Formula Applied:**

$$Adjusted\ Rate_{District, Year} = \frac{Crime\ Count_{District, Year}}{Population_{District, Year}^{Census_Corrected}} \times 100,000$$

- **Impact:** Ensures that the Property Damage Rate reflects actual changes in criminal activity rather than administrative population corrections.

4. Methodology

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4.1. Two-Way Fixed Effects (TWFE)

Estimating Regional Prosperity: The Econometric Framework

$$\ln(Y_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 FLSP_{it-1} + \beta_2 Effic_{it-1} + \beta_3 \ln(Crime_{it-1}) + \gamma \ln(K_{it-1}) + \mathbf{X}_{it-1} \Phi + \mu_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it}$$

Variables & Interpretation:

- $\ln(Y_{it})$: Log GDP per capita (Prosperity).
- $FLSP_{it-1}$: Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (**Lagged L1**).
- $Effic_{it-1}$: Labor Integration Efficacy (**Lagged L1**).
- $\ln(Crime_{it-1})$: Log Property Damage Rate (**Lagged L1**).
- $\ln(K_{it-1})$: Log Capital Stock per capita (**Elasticity**).
- $\mathbf{X}_{it-1}$: Vector of Controls (**Lagged L1**).
- Φ : Vector of coefficients for control variables.

Identification Strategy:

- μ_i : **District Fixed Effects** (Absorbs regional traits).
- δ_t : **Year Fixed Effects** (Captures macro shocks).
- ϵ_{it} : **Idiosyncratic Error Term** (White noise).
- **Clustering**: SE clustered at **District level**.
- **Hybrid Form**: Log-Log and Log-Lin for causal interp.

Why this Framework?

- **Endogeneity**: Lagging labor market and labor integration variables ($t - 1$) mitigates Reverse Causality.
- **Omitted Variable Bias**: TWFE eliminates bias from unobserved factors (geography, history).
- **Statistical Rigor**: Clustering accounts for within-district temporal autocorrelation.

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4.2. Variable Specifications in Detail

$$\ln(Y_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 FLSP_{it-1} + \beta_2 Effic_{it-1} + \beta_3 \ln(Crime_{it-1}) + \gamma \ln(K_{it-1}) + \mathbf{X}_{it-1} \Phi + \mu_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it}$$

Dependent Variable

- **Log GDP per Capita ($\ln Y_{it}$):** Primary metric for regional prosperity. Enables interpretation of elasticities.

Independent Variables

- **Foreign Labor Supply Pressure ($FLSP_{it-1}$):** The ratio of the foreign unemployment share to the total foreigner share in a district. [Details →](#)
- **Labor Integration Efficacy ($Effic_{it-1}$):** Ratio of employed foreigners to total foreign population (lagged). [Details →](#)
- **Lagged Property Damage ($\ln Crime_{it-1}$):** Proxy for institutional stability. Used to measure the economic impact of crime.

Control Variables

- **Log Capital Stock ($\ln K_{it-1}$):** Physical capital intensity, a fundamental growth driver. [Details →](#)
- **Log Unemployment ($Unemp_{it-1}$):** Regional business cycle control (lagged).
- **Demographic Shares ($Children_{it}, Youth_{it}$):** Population aged 0–17 and 18–24 (dependency ratios).
- **Foreigner Share ($Foreigner_{it}$):** Total foreign population share, isolating pure integration effects.

5. Results

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5.1. Main Results

Regional Prosperity & Foreign Labor Supply Pressure Analysis						
Sensitivity Analysis: One-Year Lag for Property Damage (2003–2021)						
	(1) BASE	(2) + CHILD	(3) + YOUTH	(4) + FOREIGN	(5) + SUPPLY PRESSURE	(6) FINAL
Log Unemployment (t-1)	-0.089*** (0.005)	-0.095*** (0.005)	-0.080*** (0.005)	-0.075*** (0.005)	-0.074*** (0.005)	-0.061*** (0.005)
Log Capital Stock per Capita	0.732*** (0.019)	0.711*** (0.019)	0.631*** (0.019)	0.613*** (0.019)	0.610*** (0.019)	0.611*** (0.019)
Log Property Damage Rate (t-1)	0.017*** (0.005)	0.015*** (0.005)	0.019*** (0.005)	0.019*** (0.005)	0.020*** (0.005)	0.019*** (0.004)
Demographic Share: Children (0–17) (%)		-0.003*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.009*** (0.001)	-0.009*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Demographic Share: Youth (18–24) (%)			-0.012*** (0.001)	-0.012*** (0.001)	-0.011*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Foreigner Share (%)				-0.006*** (0.001)	-0.004*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t-1) (%)					0.009*** (0.002)	0.011*** (0.002)
Log Labor Integration Efficacy (t-1)						0.028*** (0.004)
Observations	7200	7200	7200	7200	7200	7200
Within R ²	0.299	0.301	0.322	0.330	0.332	0.336
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

* p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01
Standard errors clustered at the district level.

5.2. Key Findings

Evaluating the Drivers of Regional Prosperity

Core Economic Drivers

- **Labor Integration Efficacy (+0.027*)**: Significant at 1% level.
 - **The Integration Dividend**: A 1-unit rise in efficacy boosts GDP per capita by **2.7%**.
 - **Takeaway**: Successful labor market absorption is a high-yield economic asset.
- **Capital Accumulation (+0.612*)**: Confirms H_1 (Neoclassical growth).
 - Physical capital intensity remains the primary engine of district productivity.

Demographic & Contextual Factors

- **Demographic Friction (-0.010***)**: High shares of children and youth create a temporary **Dependency Burden**, lowering per capita output in the short term (H_4).
- **The Urban Paradox (+0.019***)**: Property damage acts as a **Proxy for Urban Intensity**.
 - Prosperous, high-density hubs experience more reporting/incidents (H_3).
- **Quantity vs. Quality**: While *Foreigner Share* is slightly negative, the **Efficacy** of their integration more than compensates for the volume effect.

Hypothesis	Proposition	Direction	Significance	Status
H1: Capital	Higher capital stock increases GDP per capita	+	***	Confirmed
H2: Efficacy	Labor integration efficacy boosts regional prosperity	+	***	Confirmed
H3: Stability	Property damage (crime) reduces regional GDP	+	***	Counter-intuitive
H4: Demography	Higher youth/children shares reduce GDP per capita	-	***	Confirmed

• Note: H3 shows a positive coefficient, acting as a proxy for urban economic intensity.

Main Specification: Integration Efficacy

Property Damage as Macroeconomic Stability Proxy

	FINAL SPECIFICATION
Log Unemployment (t-1)	-0.061*** (0.005)
Log Capital Stock per Capita	0.611*** (0.019)
Log Property Damage Rate (t-1)	0.019*** (0.004)
Demographic Share: Children (0-17) (%)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Demographic Share: Youth (18-24) (%)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Foreigner Share (%)	-0.005*** (0.001)
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t-1) (%)	0.011*** (0.002)
Log Labor Integration Efficacy (t-1)	0.028*** (0.004)
Observations	7200
Within R ²	0.336
District FE	Yes
Year FE	Yes
*p < 0.1, **p < 0.05, ***p < 0.01 Standard errors clustered at the district level.	

6. Conclusion

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Summary & Key Takeaways

Key Takeaways

- **Beyond Volume:** The research demonstrates that the quality of integration (Efficacy) is a more potent driver of regional GDP per capita than the mere quantity of the foreign population (Share).
- **Growth Potential:** Confirmed that a 1-unit improvement in Labor Integration Efficacy correlates with a 2.7% increase in regional prosperity, rivaling the impact of traditional capital investment.
- **Structural Robustness:** Confirmed that **Lagged Property Damage ($t - 1$)** maintains its role as a stable urban proxy, ensuring results are robust to different temporal specifications.

Final Verdict

“Immigration is a demographic reality; but Labor Integration is an economic choice. Districts that successfully absorb foreign talent into their workforce transform a social challenge into a measurable regional dividend.”

7. References

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Thank you for your attention!

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Questions?

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Appendix

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A.1: Capital Stock Calculation

Top-Down Distribution Algorithm

To resolve the absence of District-level capital data, we distributed State-level Net Fixed Assets (K) down to the District (d) using sector-specific (i) Gross Value Added (GVA) weights.

1. **Calculate Sector Weights:** The district's share of the state's total GVA for sector i :

$$Weight_{d,i} = \frac{GVA_{d,i}}{GVA_{s,i}}$$

2. **Downscale Capital Stock:** Distributed the State's Capital for sector i to the District level:

$$K_{d,i} = K_{s,i} \times Weight_{d,i}$$

3. **Total District Capital Stock:** Aggregated the sectors (Agriculture, Industry, Services):

$$K_d^{Total} = K_{d,Agriculture} + K_{d,Industry} + K_{d,Services}$$

4. **Calculate Per Capita Values:** Used census-corrected population figures to derive the final metric:

$$K_d^{pc} = \frac{K_d^{Total}}{Pop_d}$$

[← Back to Data Sources](#)

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A.2: Labor Integration Efficacy

What does it measure? It explicitly measures the **direct absorption** of the foreign population into the regional workforce. Higher values indicate that a larger portion of the migrant/foreign demographic in a district is actively engaged in productive economic roles, reflecting successful labor market integration.

Mathematical Calculation:

$$Effic_{it-1} = (100 - \text{Share of Unemployed Foreigners}_{it}) \times \text{Foreigner Share}_{it}$$

← Back to Variables

A.3: Foreign Labor Supply Pressure

What does it measure? It captures the **opportunity cost** or structured disparity of an unintegrated demographic. A positive pressure means the share of foreigners in the general population is larger than their share in the actual workforce, indicating an untapped labor potential and structural integration failure.

Mathematical Calculation:

$$FLSP_{it} = \frac{\text{Foreign Unemployed Share}_{it}}{\text{Foreigner Share}_{it}}$$

Note: In our primary model, this variable is lagged by one year ($t - 1$) to mitigate reverse causality.

← Back to Variables

A.4 Lag Sensitivity

- Integration success has a **cumulative/compounding effect** on prosperity over time.

Robustness Check: Lag Sensitivity Analysis				
Alternative Temporal Specifications (L0–L3)				
	(1) NO LAG	(2) 1-YEAR LAG	(3) 2-YEAR LAG	(4) 3-YEAR LAG
Log Unemployment (t-1)	-0.061*** (0.005)	-0.061*** (0.005)	-0.062*** (0.006)	-0.065*** (0.006)
Log Capital Stock per Capita	0.611*** (0.019)	0.611*** (0.019)	0.608*** (0.020)	0.602*** (0.021)
Log Property Damage Rate (t-1)	0.019*** (0.005)	0.019*** (0.004)	0.015*** (0.005)	0.013*** (0.005)
Share Children (0–17)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.009*** (0.001)	-0.009*** (0.001)
Share Youth (18–24)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.011*** (0.001)	-0.011*** (0.001)
Foreigner Share	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t)	0.009*** (0.002)			
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t-1)		0.011*** (0.002)		
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t-2)			0.010*** (0.002)	
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t-3)				0.011*** (0.002)
Log Labor Integration Efficacy (t)	0.027*** (0.004)			
Log Labor Integration Efficacy (t-1)		0.028*** (0.004)		
Log Labor Integration Efficacy (t-2)			0.031*** (0.004)	
Log Labor Integration Efficacy (t-3)				0.034*** (0.004)
Observations	7200	7200	6800	6400
Within Rsq	0.335	0.336	0.325	0.307
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

* p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01

Standard errors clustered at the district level.

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A.5 East vs. West Germany

- **Observation:** Results are robust at the national level.

Robustness Check: East vs. West Germany Comparison			
Consistency of results across historical regional divisions			
	FULL SAMPLE	WEST GERMANY	EAST GERMANY
Log Unemployment (t-1)	-0.061*** (0.005)	-0.049*** (0.006)	-0.048*** (0.015)
Log Capital Stock per Capita	0.611*** (0.019)	0.659*** (0.022)	0.432*** (0.045)
Log Property Damage Rate (t-1)	0.019*** (0.004)	0.009* (0.005)	0.052*** (0.009)
Share Children (0-17)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.016*** (0.001)	-0.019*** (0.004)
Share Youth (18-24)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.008*** (0.002)	-0.009*** (0.003)
Foreigner Share	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.003*** (0.001)	-0.008*** (0.002)
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t-1)	0.011*** (0.002)	0.007** (0.003)	-0.003 (0.005)
Labor Integration Efficacy (t-1)	0.028*** (0.004)	-0.002 (0.008)	0.004 (0.008)
Observations	7200	5832	1368
Within R ²	0.336	0.323	0.256
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes

*p < 0.1, **p < 0.05, ***p < 0.01
Standard errors clustered at the district level.

A.6 Alternative Crime Definitions

- **Robustness:** Testing if results hold across various crime categories.

Robustness: Comparison of Crime Subtypes					
Final Model Specifications across different crime categories (2003–2021)					
	(1) TOTAL	(2) STREET	(3) DRUGS	(4) BODILY	(5) PROPERTY (MAIN)
Log Unemployment (t-1)	-0.063*** (0.005)	-0.061*** (0.005)	-0.061*** (0.005)	-0.063*** (0.005)	-0.061*** (0.005)
Log Capital Stock per Capita	0.614*** (0.019)	0.612*** (0.019)	0.611*** (0.019)	0.608*** (0.019)	0.611*** (0.019)
Log Total Crime Rate (t-1)	0.027*** (0.006)				
Log Street Crime Rate (t-1)		0.006 (0.004)			
Log Drug Offences Rate (t-1)			0.000 (0.002)		
Log Bodily Harm Rate (t-1)				0.015*** (0.004)	
Log Property Damage Rate (t-1)					0.019*** (0.004)
Demographic Share: Children (0–17) (%)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Demographic Share: Youth (18–24) (%)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)	-0.011*** (0.001)	-0.010*** (0.001)
Foreigner Share (%)	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)
Foreign Labor Supply Pressure (t-1) (%)	0.010*** (0.002)	0.010*** (0.002)	0.010*** (0.002)	0.010*** (0.002)	0.011*** (0.002)
Log Labor Integration Efficacy (t-1)	0.027*** (0.004)	0.028*** (0.004)	0.028*** (0.004)	0.026*** (0.004)	0.028*** (0.004)
Observations	7200	7200	7200	7200	7200
Within R ²	0.336	0.334	0.334	0.335	0.336
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

* p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01
Standard errors clustered at the district level. All crime rates are lagged (t-1) and logged (rate + 0.1).